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Mapping Content to Buyer Intent in AI Search [43,000+ LLM citations analyzed]

By Cate Dombrowski | February 4, 2026 | 7 min read



Mapping Content to
Buyer Intent in AI Search



- Answering informational questions, before the customer even knows they're shopping
- Establishing authority and relevance when they know they have a problem
- Winning trust and reducing risk when they're deciding what to buy

To understand what content formats get cited in AI answers at each customer journey stage, I created a framework of queries across three stages of awareness:

1. Problem Unaware: General topic questions or category exploration

"What is content marketing?"

2. Problem Aware: A pain point is present, but the buyer isn't shopping yet

"How do I scale organic campaigns profitably?"



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Type in AI Citations

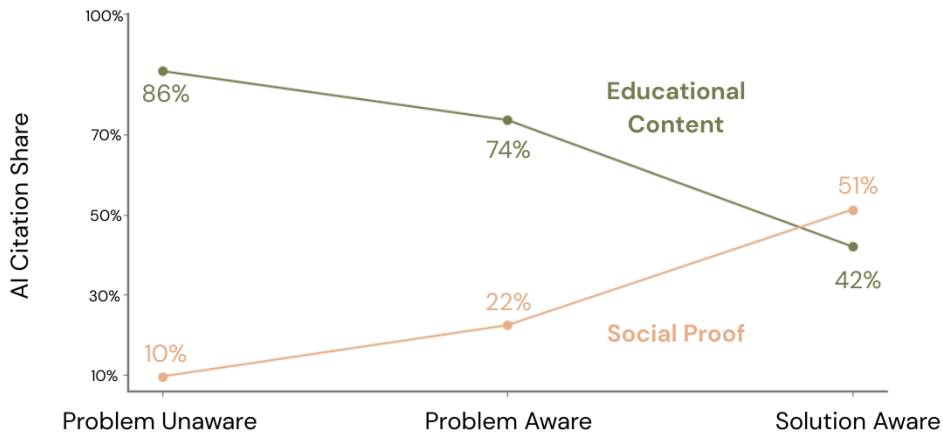
Thought Leadership

Thought Leadership

Social Proof

As purchase intent grows, AI citation share moves from educational content to social proof.

Moving down the funnel, social proof becomes increasingly more prevalent in AI citations





In Problem Unaware queries, the user is learning:

- Definitions
- Categories
- Mental Models
- How does this work?

It makes sense that the citations skew towards sources that teach. Education and Thought Leadership content dominates this stage, making up 86% of citations, including:

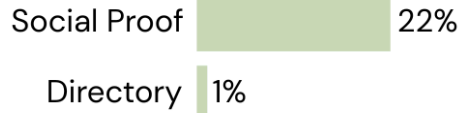


Social proof content (reviews, forums, listicles, case studies) shows up as the second most common category — but still rarely — only making up 10% of citations in Problem Unaware prompts.

Video comes in third at 2%, mostly from Youtube. And even here, video citations behave like educational content. Some examples of video titles cited in this stage include:

- “How to Keep Track of Your Conversations”
- “Why Your Google Ads Impressions Dropped”

In contrast, at the Solution Aware stage (more on this later), video citations include titles like “I Ranked Every Budgeting App, Here’s What’s ACTUALLY Good”, which reflects how video content shifts from educational toward social proof as you move down the funnel.



In Problem Aware queries, the user has a pain point. They aren't comparing brands yet, but they are looking for:

- Ways to solve a problem
- Frameworks
- Early-stage evaluation criteria

Educational content still dominates here, making up 74% of total citations. That's a slight drop from top-of-the-funnel prompts, but still clearly the majority.

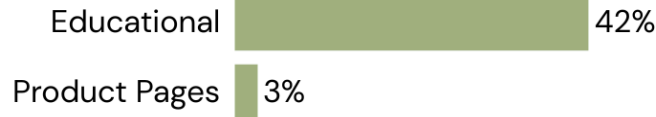


- Case Studies, 0.03%
 - AIOSEO's Maesta Case Study

That suggests that when a buyer expresses pain, LLMs begin pulling from sources that validate the experience:

- Other people describing the same problem
- Outcomes and results
- Proof that something works in practice

Directory pages like those published by Clutch and DesignRush show up third, but only make up 1% of citations in the Problem Aware stage. Directory content increases slightly to 2% in the final stage (Solution Aware), suggesting LLMs rely on directory-style information more as the buyer gets closer to purchase.



In Solution Aware prompts, the buyer is essentially asking:

- What should I buy?
- Who is winning the category?
- What do people recommend?

More than half (51%) of all LLM citations for Solution Aware queries point to social proof. At the bottom of the funnel, that looks like:

- Listicles, 47.3%

51% Social Proof



Informational posts and pages don't stop earning LLM citations at the bottom of the funnel; they just lose their monopoly.

Product pages make an appearance in third place, indicating that when a customer is asking for a solution, LLMs get information about functionality from these pages.

Methodology

I created 180 total LLM prompts, with 60 queries tailored to each customer journey stage: Problem Unaware, Problem Aware, and Solution Aware.

To reduce category bias, I ensured equal representation across industries:

- B2B SaaS: SEO, CRM Tools, and Cybersecurity
- Consumer Products: Electronics, Beauty, and Fitness



2. Directory Sites and Reference Pages: Places users go to search brands, showcasing functionality, differentiation, and general information.

- Directory sites, brand profiles, documentation and support pages such as software integrations and how the product or service works

3. Education and Thought Leadership: Owned and earned content meant to teach, persuade, and build authority.

- Blogs, how-to guides, research, trends and stats roundups

4. News and Press: Brand updates for public record.

- Funding announcements, leadership changes, software updates, and press releases



Which content types do LLMs
cite most in *branded queries*?

[Click here to read the related research](#)

Cate Dombrowski

Cate Dombrowski is a Research Analyst at Omniscient Digital, where she blends storytelling with statistics.





What We *Learned* from
Building Our Reddit
Engagement *Program*



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AI Search Strategy

What We
Learned
from
Building
Our Reddit
Engagement
Program



Allie Konchar
May 14, 2026

Your SME Content
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Content Strategy

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Cassandra Rosas
May 13, 2026

How I Created the *Perfect
Prompt Set* for AI Visibility
Research



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AI Search Research

How I
Created the
Perfect
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for AI
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Research



Cate Dombrowski
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Omniscient Digital is an organic growth agency that helps B2B software businesses turn SEO, GEO, and content into growth channels.

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